

For Milestone Architectural Ornamentation, color means cost-effective, customized, highly professional marketing collateral that's helped the company build its reputation worldwide and increase sales. Based in Amarillo, Texas, Milestone is an expert manufacturer of reproductions of ancient antiquities. The company has mastered its market, and it has done so by concentrating on the needs of its customers.

Early on, however, Milestone found it needed to stand out in the crowd. Like many companies, Milestone had a great product, but was faced with several daunting business challenges that are common to companies around the world. To succeed, it needed to make a big impact with current and future customers.

In the words of Milestone CEO Melody Brenna, "We were a little company with a totally new product, and we didn't have the sales volume or funding to hire an advertising agency. In our business, everything is ultimately visual. We have to be able to portray to a client exactly what the end project will look like to pique their interest and win the business."

The means to that end was color. And today, it's easier to use, more readily available and more cost effective than you may realize.

ENABLING SUCCESS WITH COLOR

Using color came naturally to Milestone, which relies so heavily on the visual appeal of its products. Like many businesses, it started producing its own marketing materials in-house as a way to reduce costs, increase contract closure percentages and boost quality control.

To make the most of these internal capabilities, it enlisted the help of HP printing solutions. Milestone started using HP printers for two basic reasons: ease of access to the hardware and supplies, and low price combined with high-quality results.

In addition to four HP Business Inkjet 1100 series printers, the firm's principal graphic designer Jay Ferranti uses an HP Photosmart printer for professional-quality photos in eight-color or black and white. The Photosmart printer that Ferranti uses allows direct photo printing from a digital camera, which Ferranti describes as highly useful in the brochure design process. Milestone also relies on an HP Designjet

large-format printer for line drawings, presentations and signs.

Printers are not the only HP products in use at Milestone. The company also uses HP supplies—including ink, paper and special media—because the printers and the supplies work together as a system to produce exceptional results.

COLOR SUCCESS STORY

- **Company:** Milestone Architectural Ornamentation, Amarillo, Texas
- **Challenges:** Create professional marketing collateral and proposals cost-effectively, customize proposals, print top-quality color and monochrome photos.
- **Solution:** HP Business Inkjet 1100 printers, HP Photosmart printers, HP media.
- **Results:** Individualized proposals create client trust in company's work. Eighty-five percent success rate winning business with customized packages.

"We're a very small company, but with the professional look of our proposals and posters that we print in-house, we look huge, and HP has given us that capability," says Milestone CEO Brenna. "The consistent quality and flexibility of our HP printers not only makes it possible for us to compete against much larger companies, it enables us to succeed."

CONNECTING WITH COLOR

The natural connection that Milestone made between "visual" and "color" is increasingly being made by organizations around the world that are seeking to optimize sometimes limited exposure to marketplace opportunities.

Usage of color in business documents such as presentations, sales collateral and marketing brochures, for example, bridges the gap between concept and comprehension. It connects and persuades its audience. Black and white, by comparison, is valuable in a different way—it conveys content accurately, and it provides the informational infrastructure. Color creates lasting impressions and appeals to the powerful sense of vision.

"Color is the easiest and most effective way to increase the clarity of a document," points out Robert McCullough, president of McCullough Research, in "The Definitive Guide to Office Color Printing" (realtimepublishers.com, 2004).

The guide further claims that color communications can improve comprehension by 75 percent over black-and-white communications. That's a powerful, enabling message to small and midsize businesses that are trying to carve out market share—

on any continent or in any country. So by using color in customer-facing materials, sales and marketing employees, for example, may increase their chances for success with potential customers. Color is the great equalizer, and color technology—particularly color imaging and printing—is the vehicle for that equality.

Given the increasing business value of color, it's not surprising that the market for color laser printers is taking off. And the good news for buyers is that growing popularity is driving affordability and features. According to analysts at Lyra Research, color laser printers priced under \$1,000 will account for 56 percent of total color laser printer shipments worldwide by 2008 ("Color Laser Printers: Worldwide Market Forecast and Analysis," August 2004). Lyra further predicts that by 2008, 10-23 ppm (page per minute) color laser printers will replace 1-9 ppm units as the dominant devices shipped.

DEBUNKING COLOR MYTHS

Despite numerous advantages, color imaging and printing devices may still be below the cut line on some companies' IT-budget-expenditure priority lists. Given the history, this view is a bit more understandable. At the high end, the output was good, but the devices were expensive and complex, and therefore out of reach for the average small business. At the other end of the spectrum, personal color devices also produced good output, but weren't designed for office use.

Indeed, why should an IT professional keeping a watchful eye on the budget make the commitment to color under those circumstances? The truth is that those circumstances have changed significantly. Color has become fast, affordable and practical—as well as easy to use and more reliable.

SPEED

In the past, all color laser printers